

HDDs

STORAGE IS EVERYTHING

There's just three major manufacturers left in the hard drive sector – WD, Seagate and Toshiba. Between these three manufacturers are numerous sub-brands that make up the entire consumer hard drive portfolio. In a way, it appears that hard drive manufacturers have stopped trying to outdo each other. Practically every high-end drive in the consumer market right now has the same specifications – 7200 RPM and 256 MB cache. There's hardly any reason to innovate in terms of performance given that SSDs have become quite inexpensive and almost everyone building a PC is getting one. The focus has been on increasing capacity with newer technologies. Seagate has HAMR (Heat Assisted Magnetic Recording) and WD has MAMR (Microwave Assisted Magnetic Recording) to increase storage density. Both brands are focused on catering to the data centres primarily while the consumer market appears to have taken the backseat. We ended up getting a multitude of drives this year from the manufacturers themselves as well as from NAS vendors, so we've got a pretty decent set to work with.

2018 ZERO1 AWARD WINNER WD Black 6TB

Gone are the days when the WD Black used to dominate all other drives because of its 10K RPM and massive cache. The current WD Black is a 7200 RPM drive with with 256 MB of cache and it still manages to provide decent performance compared to its own sibling, the WD Blue. However, the WD Black is still one of the best consumer drives you can get in the market. The recent addition to the WD Black lineup saw the cache getting bumped to 256 MB from 128 MB. This has helped with improving the host-to-drive speeds over other models. Moreover, this drive also has pretty decent IOPS characteristics for both 4K and 8K file sizes. For being



WD Black 6TB

Price: ₹25,999



an all-round performer, the WD Black wins the Zero1 Award this year.



Seagate Skyhawk 14TB

Price: ₹37,000
approximately



WD Blue 4TB

Price: ₹8,650/-



SkyHawk 4TB

Price: ₹8,650

RUNNER-UP Seagate Skyhawk 14TB

Seagate sent us the latest in their lineup of surveillance drives and we had some of their FireCuda SSHDs with us as well. The FireCuda not being a proper HDD, was not considered but that didn't matter since the Skyhawk more than made up for its sibling. With the ability to handle high IOPS better than most other drives in the market, the Skyhawk seems to have a natural advantage in dealing with multiple streams. Making it ideal for use cases that are the norm in the surveillance world. We should mention that the Skyhawk doesn't seem to show that much of a difference in sheer throughput. In fact, if you really wish to see this drive work wonders, then you need to benchmark it for 4K and 8K latency. That's where you find the Skyhawk widen the performance gap against the competing WD Purple. But when it came to pure throughput, the Skyhawk does lag behind the WD Black.

BEST BUY WD Blue 4TB / SkyHawk 4TB

The WD Blue and the Seagate Skyhawk continue to offer massive storage space for practically the same amount. Performance isn't key when it comes to bulk space most folks get an SSD for the boot drive. With that said, we have two contenders from both the major manufacturers sharing the Best Buy mention this year because they both cost the exact same. **A**